

Notes: Snyder & Strömberg (JPE, 2010)

Press Coverage and Political Accountability

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1 Big picture

- **Question.** Does local press coverage improve political accountability? The paper studies whether voters learn more, politicians work harder for constituents, and policy outcomes improve when newspapers have stronger incentives to cover a U.S. House representative.
- **Core shock.** The empirical variation is *congruence*: the geographic match between newspaper markets and congressional districts. When a newspaper’s readership is concentrated in one district, covering that district’s representative is more valuable to the newspaper.
- **Mechanism chain.** Congruence increases newspaper coverage of representatives; more coverage increases voter knowledge; informed voters monitor representatives more effectively; representatives respond by working more for the district; and districts receive more federal funds.
- **Main empirical result.** Moving from low to high congruence is associated with substantially more newspaper articles about the representative, greater voter recall and evaluation of the representative, lower roll-off, higher turnout, larger incumbency advantage, more constituency-oriented behavior, and higher federal spending per capita.
- **Interpretation.** The paper is not simply about media consumption. It is about how the shape of media markets changes politicians’ incentives by changing the probability that local constituents observe their behavior.
- **Political economy lesson.** Accountability depends on information flows. A free press may exist, but if media-market boundaries do not match political boundaries, many voters may receive little relevant information about their own representatives.

1.1 Incremental contribution of the paper

- **A geographic instrument-like source of variation.** Earlier work documented correlations between press freedom, media coverage, and governance, but separating causality from citizen interest and politician behavior is difficult. This paper uses the mismatch between newspaper markets and electoral districts as a quasi-exogenous source of variation in coverage incentives.
- **Complete accountability chain.** The paper does not stop at voter information. It follows the full chain from coverage to voter knowledge, to electoral participation, to congressional effort, to roll-call behavior, to federal spending.
- **Local political information rather than general political sophistication.** By showing effects on House-representative knowledge but not on senator knowledge or knowledge of congressional majorities, the paper separates district-specific information from general political engagement.
- **Media-market design matters.** The paper highlights that political accountability can depend on the economic geography of newspapers and television markets, not only on formal electoral rules.
- **Empirical strategy for media effects.** The congruence design, redistricting tests, within-race specifications, and neighboring-county comparisons became a template for later work on local media, information, and political accountability.

2 Data and measurement

2.1 Newspaper-market data and coverage construction

- The paper combines newspaper circulation data with congressional district boundaries to measure the fit between newspaper markets and districts.
- Newspaper circulation comes from county-level sales data. The main object is how many copies of a newspaper are sold in each county, and how those counties map into congressional districts.

- Newspaper article coverage is measured by counting articles that mention U.S. House representatives in newspaper archives, online editions, Lexis/Nexis, and newspaper websites.
- The coverage sample contains newspaper-by-congressman observations for 1991–2000.
- The dependent variable in the coverage test is the number of articles in newspaper m mentioning representative d during congressional session t .

Interpretation: The coverage data are used to validate the first stage: newspapers with more readers in a district write more about that district’s representative. This matters because all later outcomes use congruence as the source of variation, not direct article counts for every district-year.

2.2 ReaderShare and Congruence

For newspaper m and congressional district d , define

$$\text{ReaderShare}_{md} = \frac{\text{circulation of newspaper } m \text{ inside district } d}{\text{total circulation of newspaper } m}.$$

The first-stage coverage equation is

$$q_{md} = \alpha_0 + \alpha_1 \text{ReaderShare}_{md} + u_{md},$$

where q_{md} is the number of articles newspaper m writes about the representative from district d .

For county c inside district d , define market-share-weighted congruence:

$$\text{Congruence}_{cd} = \sum_m \text{MarketShare}_{mc} \text{ReaderShare}_{md},$$

where MarketShare_{mc} is newspaper m ’s share of newspaper sales in county c .

Interpretation: Congruence is high when the newspapers read by county residents mostly sell inside the same congressional district. It is low when residents read newspapers whose audiences are spread across many other districts. This is not simply newspaper penetration; it is the alignment of readers and political jurisdiction.

2.3 Voter-level ANES outcomes

- Voter outcomes come from the American National Election Studies (ANES), 1984–2004.
- Key outcomes measure whether respondents read about the incumbent, can recall or recognize House candidates, provide a feeling thermometer rating, provide ideological placement, or state likes/dislikes about the representative.
- Placebo political-knowledge outcomes include recall of senators and knowledge of which party controlled the House or Senate.
- Alternative information-channel variables include hearing about the incumbent on television or radio, meeting the incumbent, receiving mail, or attending events.

Interpretation: The ANES variables let the paper distinguish real information about the local representative from general political interest. The strongest effects appear on district-specific knowledge, which supports the newspaper mechanism.

2.4 Election outcomes

- Voting outcomes include turnout, roll-off in House elections relative to presidential elections, incumbent vote shares, and incumbency advantage.
- The paper uses county-by-district election data and congressional-district election outcomes.
- Some specifications examine close races and within-race variation, and others exploit changes from redistricting.

Interpretation: If media coverage improves accountability, it should affect not only survey knowledge but also actual electoral behavior. Higher turnout and lower roll-off mean voters are more willing to participate in House races.

2.5 Congressional behavior and policy outcomes

- Congressional behavior outcomes include witness appearances before hearings, committee assignments, party-loyalty roll-call voting, and NOMINATE ideology scores.
- Witness appearances capture effort to secure benefits or attention for the district.
- Committee variables separate distributive committees from policy committees.
- Party loyalty measures the share of roll-call votes aligned with party leadership.
- Federal spending data measure county-level federal expenditures per capita.

Interpretation: These variables move the analysis from voter information to politician behavior and policy allocation. The paper asks whether representatives actually behave differently when voters are more likely to observe them.

3 Empirical specifications

3.1 Coverage first stage

The newspaper-level coverage test is

$$\text{Articles}_{mdt} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{ReaderShare}_{mdt} + X'_{mdt} \gamma + \tau_t + \varepsilon_{mdt}.$$

At the county-district level, the equivalent relationship is

$$\text{Exposure}_{cdt} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Congruence}_{cdt} + X'_{cdt} \gamma + \tau_t + \varepsilon_{cdt}.$$

Interpretation: A positive β_1 validates the logic that congruent newspaper markets produce more coverage of the relevant representative. Without this relationship, later reduced-form effects of congruence would be hard to interpret as media effects.

3.2 Voter knowledge and information outcomes

The typical voter-level specification is

$$Y_{icdt} = \alpha + \beta \text{Congruence}_{cdt} + X'_{icdt} \gamma + \mu_{st} + \eta_r + \varepsilon_{icdt},$$

where Y is a knowledge or information outcome, μ_{st} are state-by-year fixed effects, and η_r may include incumbent or race fixed effects depending on the specification.

Interpretation: The coefficient β measures whether voters in more congruent media environments know more about their House representative. The identifying assumption is that conditional on controls and fixed effects, congruence changes newspaper incentives but does not directly change voter knowledge except through information exposure.

3.3 Within-race and redistricting specifications

The paper uses two stronger designs:

- **Within-race.** Compare voters in the same congressional district and election but in counties with different congruence.
- **Redistricting.** Use changes in congruence caused by changes in district boundaries, holding constant state-year and county features.

$$Y_{icdt} = \beta \text{Congruence}_{cdt} + \delta_{dt} + X'_{icdt} \gamma + \varepsilon_{icdt}$$

for within-race designs, where δ_{dt} are district-by-year fixed effects.

Interpretation: These designs are central because they rule out many confounds. Within-race comparisons hold constant the candidates, campaign, and district-level election environment. Redistricting focuses on changes in congruence generated by political boundary changes rather than persistent county traits.

3.4 Politician behavior and policy outcomes

Representative-level and county-level outcome regressions have the form

$$Y_{dt} = \alpha + \beta \text{Congruence}_{dt} + X'_{dt} \gamma + \text{fixed effects} + \varepsilon_{dt}.$$

For federal spending, the unit is county-by-congressional-session:

$$\log(\text{Spending per capita}_{cdt}) = \alpha + \beta \text{Congruence}_{cdt} + X'_{cdt} \gamma + \text{fixed effects} + \varepsilon_{cdt}.$$

Interpretation: These are reduced-form accountability regressions. They estimate whether districts with more relevant local news receive more effort and resources from representatives. They are less mechanically tied to individual learning than the ANES outcomes, but they are the key policy implications.

4 Identification strategy

4.1 Core identifying variation

The key idea is that newspaper markets and congressional districts are drawn by different forces. Newspaper markets follow economic geography, commuting patterns, and historical newspaper circulation. Congressional districts follow political redistricting rules and population constraints. Their overlap is therefore plausibly partly accidental.

Interpretation: If the overlap is quasi-random after controls, then congruence changes the local newspaper's incentive to cover a representative without directly changing voters' preferences or the representative's ability.

4.2 First-stage logic

The first-stage condition is that congruence must strongly predict coverage. The paper shows that Reader-Share and Congruence have large positive effects on the number of articles about a House representative.

Interpretation: This first stage links the geographic design to actual media coverage. It also establishes the magnitude: moving from low to high congruence corresponds to roughly hundreds of additional articles in the coverage sample.

4.3 Balance and placebo logic

- Congruence should not be strongly related to unrelated political knowledge.
- Congruence should predict newspaper exposure, not just general TV/radio exposure or campaign contact.
- Congruence should not simply proxy for political interest, education, urbanization, or turnout culture.

Interpretation: Placebo tests using senator knowledge and knowledge of congressional party majorities are especially important. If congruence only captured political sophistication, it would predict these outcomes too. It does not.

4.4 Alternative-channel tests

The paper explicitly compares newspaper congruence with TV congruence. It also controls for and tests campaign contacts, mail, and direct meetings.

Interpretation: The pattern supports a newspaper channel: TVCongruence predicts hearing about representatives on TV but does not explain name recall, while newspaper congruence predicts reading about the representative and knowledge of the representative.

4.5 Redistricting and neighboring-county evidence

Redistricting changes the alignment between counties and congressional districts while holding many county-level characteristics fixed. Neighboring-county designs compare nearby counties with similar local economic and social environments but different congruence.

Interpretation: These tests reduce concerns that high-congruence counties are simply more civic, richer, more urban, or more politically interested. They are not perfect experiments, but they are substantially more credible than simple cross-sectional correlations.

4.6 Threats to interpretation

- **Endogenous districting.** If congressional boundaries are drawn to match media markets or political communities, congruence might reflect underlying political structure. Redistricting and fixed-effect tests mitigate but do not eliminate this concern.
- **Demand for political news.** Newspapers may cover representatives more because readers are more politically interested. Placebo knowledge tests and within-race comparisons reduce this concern.
- **Other local institutions.** Congruence might correlate with civic organizations, local parties, or local identity. Neighboring-county and state-by-year designs help address this.

- **Policy outcome endogeneity.** Spending and representative behavior are less directly tied to information than survey outcomes. The evidence is best interpreted as a broad accountability pattern, not a randomized policy experiment.

Interpretation: The identification is strongest for the media-coverage and voter-information links, and somewhat weaker but still suggestive for congressional behavior and spending.

5 Figures and tables

5.1 Figure 1: Structure of empirical investigation

Read: Figure 1 organizes the paper’s entire empirical argument. It shows the sequence from newspaper market congruence to coverage, voter information, voter behavior, politician behavior, and policy outcomes. The scatterplots show strong bivariate relationships: congruence is positively related to coverage, knowledge, turnout, witness appearances, and federal spending, and negatively related to party loyalty.

Interpretation: The figure is not causal by itself, but it gives the paper’s organizing structure. The later tables ask whether these bivariate relationships survive controls and stronger designs.

Economic message: Media geography matters because it determines which politicians voters learn about. Accountability is weaker when newspapers have little economic reason to cover a district’s representative.

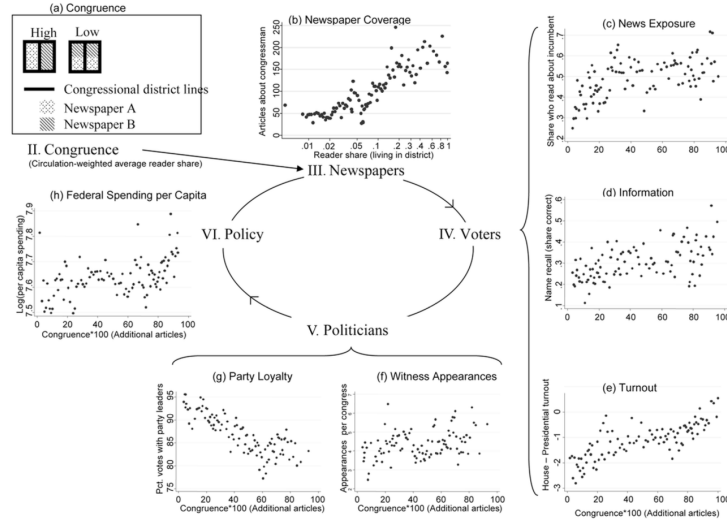


FIG. 1.—Structure of empirical investigation

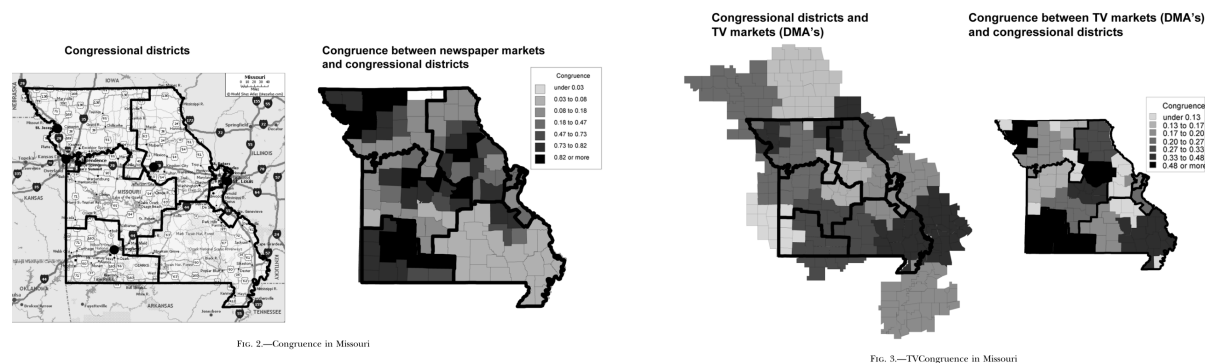
Figure 1: Structure of empirical investigation

5.2 Figures 2–3: Congruence in Missouri and TVCongruence in Missouri

Read: Figure 2 illustrates newspaper congruence in Missouri. Counties whose residents read newspapers concentrated in their own congressional district have high congruence. Figure 3 constructs the analogous measure for television markets.

Interpretation: These maps make the identifying variation concrete. Congruence is not a politician characteristic. It changes because media markets and political jurisdictions overlap differently across space.

Economic message: The same voter can be represented by a House member whom local newspapers either cover heavily or barely cover, depending on the newspaper’s audience footprint.



(a) Figure 2: Congruence in Missouri

(b) Figure 3: TVCongruence in Missouri

5.3 Table 1: Newspaper Data: Summary Statistics and Table 2: Newspaper Coverage of U.S. House Members, 1991–2000

Read: Table 1 shows that the average newspaper-district observation has 101 articles about the congressman and average ReaderShare of 0.16. Table 2 shows a very strong first stage: ReaderShare and Congruence strongly predict articles about the representative.

Interpretation: The coefficient on ReaderShare implies that newspapers cover representatives much more when a larger share of their readers live in the representative’s district. This is the crucial behavioral mechanism on the newspaper side.

Economic message: Newspapers allocate scarce political coverage toward representatives relevant to their readers. That commercial incentive produces unequal political information across voters.

Variable	Observations	Mean	Standard Deviation	Minimum	Maximum
Articles about congressman	4,206	101	97	0	1,454
ReaderShare	4,206	.16	.22	0	1
Circulation (100,000s)	4,206	3.41	2.70	.01	11.68
Scandal	4,206	.02	.13	0	1
Party leader	4,206	.01	.14	0	2
Higher office	4,206	.03	.17	0	1
Out of state	4,206	.13	.33	0	1
Close race	4,206	.26	.16	0	.50
Freshman	4,206	.14	.35	0	1
Retired	4,206	.09	.28	0	1
% urban	4,206	.68	.30	0	1
Median income	4,206	.37	.10	.15	.64

(a) Table 1: Newspaper Data: Summary Statistics

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
ReaderShare	177.25 (17.95)***	164.14 (17.06)***		
Congruence			171.10 (19.42)***	170.64 (6.18)***
Party leader		154.62 (50.53)***	191.93 (72.45)***	122.70 (10.65)***
Scandal		70.21 (18.24)***	82.15 (27.37)***	45.17 (10.76)***
Higher_office (ran or appointed)		90.25 (11.22)***	98.21 (13.02)***	82.61 (8.25)***
Out_of_state		−34.75 (9.38)***	−10.45 (12.26)	−19.99 (4.19)***
Close_race		36.02 (16.87)**	53.63 (20.56)**	33.00 (11.01)***
Freshman		5.32 (3.63)	8.07 (5.08)	9.66 (4.09)**
Retired		18.38 (7.42)**	29.43 (9.26)***	19.94 (5.88)***
% urban		−18.40 (12.39)	.19 (13.37)	−34.36 (5.40)***
Median income		24.67 (37.71)	14.57 (45.38)	−24.79 (17.78)
Observations	4,206	4,206	2,308	3,421
R ²	.18	.27	.26	.28

NOTE.—Results are from OLS regressions. In cols. 1 and 2, the unit of observation is a newspaper by congress. All regressions include year fixed effects. In col. 3, the unit of observation is a congressional district by congress; in col. 4, it is congressional district by county by congress. Robust standard errors, clustered by newspaper, are in parentheses.
* Significant at 10 percent.
** Significant at 5 percent.
*** Significant at 1 percent.

(b) Table 2: Newspaper Coverage of U.S. House Members

5.4 Table 3: ANES Data: Summary Statistics and Table 4: Voter Knowledge of House Representative

Read: Table 3 summarizes the voter knowledge outcomes. Table 4 shows that congruence strongly predicts reading about the incumbent, recalling a candidate’s name, providing a feeling thermometer rating, placing the representative ideologically, and giving likes/dislikes.

Interpretation: The effects survive baseline controls, within-race designs, and redistricting specifications. The consistency across knowledge measures is important: the effect is not limited to one survey question.

Economic message: Newspaper coverage increases citizens’ usable information about their own representatives. This is the microfoundation for accountability effects later in the paper.

5.5 Tables 5–7: Placebo Knowledge, Television and Radio, and Other Information Channels

Read: Table 5 shows that congruence does not predict general political knowledge, such as senator recall or knowledge of which party controls Congress. Table 6 compares newspapers with TV and radio. Table 7 checks campaign contacts and other nonmedia channels.

Interpretation: These tables are identification checks. The paper needs to show that congruence is not just political interest or campaign intensity. The results point specifically to local newspaper information about the House representative.

Economic message: The media effect is content-specific. Congruent newspapers inform voters about the representative they cover, not about politics in general.

TABLE 3
ANES DATA: SUMMARY STATISTICS

Variable	Observations	Mean	Standard Deviation	Minimum	Maximum
Congruence	15,014	.46	.29	.01	.97
ReadAboutIncumbent	8,985	.5	.5	0	1
ReadAboutChallenger	8,957	.17	.38	0	1
NameRecall	14,139	.31	.46	0	1
NameRecallIncumbent	11,734	.29	.45	0	1
NameRecallChallenger	11,734	.11	.32	0	1
NameRecognition	9,624	.92	.28	0	1
FeelingThermometerProvided	12,459	.82	.38	0	1
IdeologicalRatingProvided	7,441	.7	.46	0	1
LikesOrDislikesProvided	10,775	.53	.5	0	1
NameRecallSenator	5,337	.46	.5	0	1
FeelingThermometerSenator	6,441	.91	.29	0	1
KnowsHouseMajority	14,153	.56	.5	0	1
KnowsSenateMajority	14,146	.5	.5	0	1
Hear about incumbent on TV	8,985	.5	.5	0	1
Hear about incumbent on radio	8,985	.26	.44	0	1

Table 3: ANES Data: Summary Statistics

TABLE 4
VOTER KNOWLEDGE OF HOUSE REPRESENTATIVE

	BASELINE		WITHIN- RACE	REDISTRICTING
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fixed effects	Year	State × year	District × year	State × year, county
Dependent Variable: ReadAboutIncumbent				
Congruence	.29 (.08)***	.42 (.09)***	.40 (.12)***	.30 (.09)***
Observations	8,985	8,985	8,985	8,985
R ²	.12	.22	.24	.18
Dependent Variable: NameRecall				
Congruence	.28 (.07)***	.35 (.07)***	.42 (.07)***	.27 (.06)***
Observations	14,139	14,139	14,139	14,139
R ²	.16	.27	.30	.24
Dependent Variable: NameRecognition				
Congruence	.04 (.05)	.08 (.05)	.10 (.06)*	.07 (.06)
Observations	9,624	9,624	9,624	9,624
R ²	.27	.39	.42	.31
Dependent Variable: FeelingThermometerProvided				
Congruence	.21 (.05)***	.20 (.06)***	.19 (.07)***	.29 (.09)***
Observations	12,459	12,459	12,459	12,459
R ²	.18	.25	.28	.19
Dependent Variable: IdeologicalRatingProvided				
Congruence	.22 (.09)***	.25 (.09)***	.30 (.10)***	.20 (.09)**
Observations	7,441	7,441	7,441	7,441
R ²	.18	.25	.27	.19
Dependent Variable: LikesOrDislikesProvided				
Congruence	.28 (.08)***	.26 (.09)***	.21 (.09)**	.30 (.07)***
Observations	10,775	10,775	10,775	10,775
R ²	.17	.29	.32	.24

NOTE.—Results are from OLS regressions. Robust standard errors, clustered by county, are in parentheses.
* Significant at 10 percent.
** Significant at 5 percent.
*** Significant at 1 percent.

Table 4: Voter Knowledge of House Representative

TABLE 5
PLACEBO: GENERAL POLITICAL KNOWLEDGE

	DEPENDENT VARIABLE			
	NameRecall Senator (1)	Feeling Thermometer Senator (2)	KnowsHouse Majority (3)	KnowsSenate Majority (4)
Congruence	.04 (.14)	-.02 (.09)	.00 (.05)	.03 (.06)
Observations	5,337	6,441	14,153	14,146
R ²	.30	.22	.31	.27

NOTE.—Results are from OLS regressions. All regressions include state × year and incumbent fixed effects and controls ("baseline specification"). Robust standard errors, clustered by county, are in parentheses.

(a) Table 5: Placebo: General Political Knowledge

TABLE 6
TELEVISION AND RADIO

	DEPENDENT VARIABLE			
	Read/Hear about Representative from			
	Newspaper (1)	Radio (2)	Television (3)	NameRecall (4)
Congruence	.44 (.10)***	.09 (.07)	.19 (.11)*	.32 (.09)***
TVCongruence	-.28 (.22)	.63 (.19)***	.68 (.22)***	.17 (.18)
Observations	8,985	8,985	8,985	14,139
R ²	.22	.16	.24	.27

NOTE.—Results are from OLS regressions. All regressions include state × year and incumbent fixed effects and controls ("baseline specification"). Robust standard errors, clustered by county, are in parentheses.
* Significant at 10 percent.
** Significant at 5 percent.
*** Significant at 1 percent.

(b) Table 6: Television and Radio

TABLE 7
OTHER INFORMATION CHANNELS

	Meet with Staff	Meet Incumbent	Attend Gathering	Receive Mail
Congruence	.05 (.05)	.14 (.07)*	.12 (.08)	.16 (.09)*
Observations	8,985	8,985	8,985	8,985
R ²	.13	.16	.15	.24

NOTE.—Results are from OLS regressions. All regressions include state × year and incumbent fixed effects and controls ("baseline specification"). Robust standard errors, clustered by county, are in parentheses.

* Significant at 10 percent.
** Significant at 5 percent.
*** Significant at 1 percent.

Table 7: Other Information Channels

5.6 Tables 8–10: Voting Data, Roll-Off for House Relative to President, and Incumbent and Challenger Effects

Read: Table 8 summarizes election outcomes. Table 9 shows that congruence reduces roll-off in House elections relative to presidential voting. Table 10 separates effects on incumbent and challenger information.

Interpretation: Roll-off is a revealed-behavior measure of low information or low engagement in House races. Lower roll-off in high-congruence places means voters are more willing to cast House votes when they receive relevant local news.

Economic message: Information affects electoral participation, not only survey responses. Voters are more likely to engage in House races when their newspapers cover those races and representatives.

TABLE 8
VOTING DATA: SUMMARY STATISTICS

Variable	Observations	Mean	Standard Deviation	Minimum	Maximum
Democratic vote share	17,312	48	19	0	100
Incumbent vote share	17,312	66	12	0	100
Congruence	17,312	.49	.3	0	1
House election turnout	9,553	41.1	9.1	1.4	99.9
Presidential election turnout	9,553	42.3	8.7	4.1	101.9
Roll-off for House relative to president	9,553	1.2	3.6	−53.3	54.4
House election turnout (top of ticket)	999	31	9	5	71

(a) Table 8: Voting Data: Summary Statistics

TABLE 9
ROLL-OFF FOR HOUSE RELATIVE TO PRESIDENT

	BASELINE		WITHIN-RACE		REDISTRICTING	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Congruence	−.75 (.13)***	−.64 (.13)***	−.75 (.13)***	−.70 (.13)***	−.86 (.42)**	−.81 (.42)*
Presidential election turnout	.08 (.01)***	.12 (.01)***	.07 (.01)***	.10 (.01)***	.17 (.02)***	.18 (.02)***
Controls	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
Fixed effects	State × year	State × year	District × year	District × year	State × year, county	State × year, county
Observations	9,553	9,553	9,553	9,553	9,553	9,553
R ²	.42	.45	.57	.58	.64	.65

NOTE.—Results are from OLS regressions. The unit of observation is county by district by election. Standard errors, clustered by county, are in parentheses.

* Significant at 10 percent.

** Significant at 5 percent.

*** Significant at 1 percent.

(b) Table 9: Roll-Off for House Relative to President

TABLE 10
INCUMBENT AND CHALLENGER EFFECTS

	READ ABOUT		NAME RECALL	
	Incumbent	Challenger	Incumbent	Challenger
Congruence	.38 (.12)***	.05 (.10)	.34 (.09)***	.11 (.05)**
Observations	5,945	5,930	10,424	10,424
R ²	.24	.29	.29	.30

NOTE.—Results are from OLS regressions. Subsample is contested elections. All regressions include state × year and incumbent fixed effects and controls (“baseline specification”). Robust standard errors, clustered by county, are in parentheses.

* Significant at 10 percent.

** Significant at 5 percent.

*** Significant at 1 percent.

Table 10: Incumbent and Challenger Effects

5.7 Table 11: Incumbency Advantage

Read: Table 11 estimates whether congruence strengthens the electoral advantage of incumbents. The incumbent-by-congruence interaction is positive across several specifications.

Interpretation: A better-informed electorate may reward known incumbents, and the local newspaper coverage generated by congruence can increase the incumbent’s electoral advantage. This does not mean

voters blindly support incumbents; it means information changes the electoral production of candidate recognition and evaluation.

Economic message: Media coverage can shape electoral advantage by increasing the visibility of representatives.

TABLE 11
INCUMBENCY ADVANTAGE
Dependent Variable: Democratic Percentage of Two-Party Vote

	LEVITT AND WOLFRAM		BASELINE		WITHIN-RACE		REDISTRICTING	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Incumbent	9.21 (.23)***	10.17 (.27)***	8.29 (1.39)***	9.32 (1.25)***			10.82 (1.92)***	12.49 (1.78)***
Incumbent × Congruence	.66 (.27)**	.67 (.26)***	1.13 (.30)***	.77 (.30)**	.60 (.26)**	.74 (.26)***	1.49 (.46)***	1.25 (.44)***
Congruence	.82 (.28)***	.78 (.27)***	1.81 (.31)***	1.56 (.30)***	.65 (.27)**	.67 (.26)***	2.59 (.74)***	2.55 (.73)***
Presidential vote share	.74 (.01)***	.74 (.01)***	.66 (.01)***	.67 (.01)***	.76 (.01)***	.75 (.01)***	.61 (.02)***	.59 (.02)***
Democratic incumbent			1.35 (1.38)	.61 (1.25)			−1.19 (1.92)	−2.48 (1.77)
Lagged Democratic vote			22.90 (1.11)***	20.13 (1.13)***			19.15 (1.42)***	16.77 (1.40)***
Controls	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
Fixed effects	State × year, district × plan	State × year, district × plan	State × year	State × year	District × year	District × year	State × year, county	State × year, county
Observations	17,312	17,312	14,227	14,227	14,227	14,227	14,227	14,227
R ²	.89	.90	.86	.87	.94	.95	.91	.92

NOTE.—Results are from OLS regressions. The unit of observation is county by district by election. Standard errors, clustered by county, are in parentheses.
* Significant at 10 percent.
** Significant at 5 percent.
*** Significant at 1 percent.

Table 11: Incumbency Advantage

5.8 Tables 12–14: Representatives in Congress, Witness Appearances, and Committee Assignments

Read: Table 12 summarizes representative-level outcomes. Table 13 shows that congruent districts have representatives who appear more often as witnesses before congressional hearings. Table 14 provides weaker evidence on committee assignments: congruence is associated with more distributive committee assignments in simple specifications and fewer policy committee assignments in some specifications.

Interpretation: The witness-appearance results are strong evidence of effort. Representatives from better-monitored districts appear to work harder to advocate for constituents. Committee results are more mixed, likely because committee assignments depend on party, seniority, and chamber constraints.

Economic message: Accountability affects legislative behavior. Politicians in more visible districts choose actions that are more observable and beneficial to constituents.

TABLE 12
REPRESENTATIVES IN CONGRESS: SUMMARY STATISTICS

Variable	Observations	Mean	Standard Deviation	Minimum	Maximum
Congruence	4,784	.45	.24	0	1
Witness	4,890	3.54	3.54	0	28
WitnessBudget	4,890	1.55	2.20	0	21
PartyLoyalty	4,534	83.93	10.20	31.65	100
NominateScores	3,959	0	.42	−.87	1
DistribComm	4,508	.27	.44	0	1
PolicyComm	4,771	.16	.36	0	1

Table 12: Representatives in Congress: Summary Statistics

TABLE 13
DEPENDENT VARIABLE: NUMBER OF WITNESS APPEARANCES BEFORE CONGRESSIONAL HEARINGS

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
Congruence	.41 (.17)**	.42 (.16)***	.41 (.15)***	.43 (.21)**	.41 (.18)**	.44 (.23)*	.38 (.22)*
District controls	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Race and representative controls			X	X	X	X	X
Fixed effects	State, year	State, year	State, year	District, year	Rep., year	State, year	State, year
Estimation procedure	Poisson	NB	NB	NB	NB	Poisson	NB
Appearance before committee	All	All	All	All	All	Appr., W&M	Appr., W&M
Observations	4,890	4,890	4,890	4,890	4,890	4,890	4,890

NOTE.—Estimation procedure: NB = negative binomial regression; Poisson = Poisson regression. The unit of observation is House representative by congressional session. Appearance before committee: Appr. = Appropriations; W&M = Ways and Means. Standard errors, clustered by congressional district, are in parentheses.
* Significant at 10 percent.
** Significant at 5 percent.
*** Significant at 1 percent.

(a) Table 13: Witness Appearances before Hearings

TABLE 14
COMMITTEE ASSIGNMENTS

	DEPENDENT VARIABLE					
	Distributive Committee Assignment			Policy Committee Assignment		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Congruence	.41 (.07)***	.15 (.09)	.05 (.08)	-.18 (.06)***	-.07 (.08)	-.21 (.07)***
Controls	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Fixed effects	State × year	State × year	State × year	State × year	State × year	State × year
Observations	4,508	4,508	4,508	4,771	4,771	4,771
R ²	.18	.37	.56	.12	.24	.54

NOTE.—Results are from OLS regressions. The unit of observation is House representative by congressional session. Standard errors clustered by House representative are in parentheses.
* Significant at 10 percent.
** Significant at 5 percent.
*** Significant at 1 percent.

(b) Table 14: Committee Assignments

5.9 Table 15 and Figure 4: Party Loyalty and Nominate Scores by Congruence

Read: Table 15 shows that representatives from more congruent districts vote less often with party leadership. Figure 4 plots NOMINATE scores around close elections and shows more moderation in high-congruence districts.

Interpretation: If voters observe representatives better, representatives have stronger incentives to serve constituency interests rather than simply follow party leadership. The party-loyalty result is one of the strongest politician-behavior findings.

Economic message: Local information can weaken party discipline by making representatives more accountable to their districts.

TABLE 15
DEPENDENT VARIABLE: PERCENTAGE OF ROLL CALL VOTES WITH PARTY LEADERSHIP

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Congruence	-5.38 (2.06)***	-4.75 (2.03)**	-4.65 (2.21)**	-6.75 (2.63)**	-3.27 (1.40)**
District controls	X	X	X	X	X
Race and representative controls		X	X	X	X
Fixed effects	State, year	State, year	State × year	District, state × year	Rep., state × year
Observations	4,534	4,534	4,534	4,534	4,534
R ²	.19	.32	.38	.68	.91

NOTE.—Results are from OLS regressions. The unit of observation is House representative by congressional session. Standard errors, clustered by congressional district, are in parentheses.
* Significant at 10 percent.
** Significant at 5 percent.
*** Significant at 1 percent.

(a) Table 15: Party Loyalty

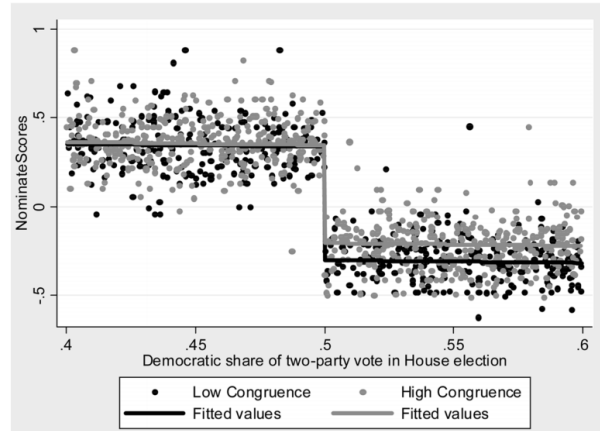


FIG. 4.—Nominate scores by Congruence

(b) Figure 4: Nominate Scores by Congruence

5.10 Table 16: Nominate Scores First Dimension

Read: Table 16 formalizes the Figure 4 pattern. The interaction between Democratic victory and congruence is positive, meaning that the ideological discontinuity at the party threshold is smaller in high-congruence districts.

Interpretation: The result supports moderation: when voters are better informed, elected representatives are less extreme relative to the party switch. The design compares close Democratic and Republican wins, controlling flexibly for vote shares.

Economic message: Better local press coverage makes representatives more responsive to the median voter rather than only to party positions.

TABLE 16
DEPENDENT VARIABLE: NOMINATE SCORES FIRST DIMENSION

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
(Democrats win) × Congruence	.18 (.05)***	.16 (.05)***	.18 (.06)***	.16 (.05)***	.15 (.06)***
Democrats win	-.75 (.03)***	-.75 (.03)***	-.81 (.08)***	-.75 (.03)***	-.80 (.09)***
Congruence	-.04 (.04)	-.09 (.04)**	-.09 (.05)*	-.06 (.04)	-.04 (.04)
Controls	No	Main	Main, urban interacted	No	Main, urban interacted
Fixed effects	No	No	No	Year, district	Year, district
Observations	3,959	3,959	3,959	3,959	3,959
R ²	.87	.90	.90	.96	.96

NOTE.—Results are from OLS regressions. The unit of observation is House representative by congressional session. All specifications control for fifth-order polynomials in Democratic vote share in the House and presidential elections. The “main” controls denote the direct effect of all our control variables. The “urban interacted” controls denote interaction between the Democrats win dummy variable and share urban, density, and the 10 dummy variables for urban and density. Standard errors, clustered by congressional district, are in parentheses.

* Significant at 10 percent.

** Significant at 5 percent.

*** Significant at 1 percent.

Table 16: Nominate Scores First Dimension

5.11 Table 17: Distribution of Federal Funds across Counties, 1984–2004

Read: Table 17 shows that counties with higher congruence receive more federal spending per capita. The result survives baseline controls, within-race comparisons, neighboring-county comparisons, and redistricting-based specifications.

Interpretation: This is the policy-outcome culmination of the paper. If press coverage improves accountability, representatives should bring more resources to their districts. The spending result is consistent with that mechanism, though it is more reduced-form than the voter-information results.

Economic message: Local press coverage has real distributive consequences. Information affects not only what voters know but also what districts receive.

TABLE 17
DISTRIBUTION OF FEDERAL FUNDS ACROSS COUNTIES, 1984–2004
Dependent Variable: Log Spending per Capita

	BASELINE		WITHIN-RACE		WITHIN NEIGHBOR COUNTIES		REDISTRICTING	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Congruence	.092 (.030)***	.137 (.027)***	.064 (.030)**	.094 (.030)***	.106 (.039)***	.096 (.038)**	.051 (.021)**	.035 (.020)*
Controls	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
Fixed effects	State × year	State × year	District × year	District × year	Year, neighbor	Year, neighbor	State × year, county	State × year, county
Observations	33,085	33,085	28,787	28,787	16,698	16,698	33,085	33,085
R ²	.259	.393	.441	.516	.638	.677	.8	.890

NOTE.—Results are from OLS regressions. The unit of observation is county by congressional session. Standard errors, clustered by county, are in parentheses.

* Significant at 10 percent.

** Significant at 5 percent.

*** Significant at 1 percent.

Table 17: Distribution of Federal Funds across Counties, 1984–2004

6 Interpretive synthesis

- **The mechanism is layered.** Congruence affects news coverage, coverage affects voter knowledge, informed voters change electoral incentives, and politicians respond with effort and policy choices.
- **The strongest evidence is the first half of the chain.** Newspaper coverage and voter knowledge respond very clearly to congruence. These results are supported by strong first-stage and placebo tests.
- **The political-behavior evidence is consistent but more reduced-form.** Witness appearances, party loyalty, moderation, and spending align with accountability theory, though these outcomes can be affected by many other political factors.
- **The paper identifies a media-market externality.** A county can be poorly informed not because its citizens are uninterested, but because the newspapers they read have little incentive to cover their representative.
- **The results matter for institutional design.** Redistricting, media consolidation, newspaper decline, and local-news subsidies all can affect accountability by changing the information environment.

7 Short summary

- Snyder and Strömberg study how local press coverage affects political accountability.
- The key measure is congruence, the match between newspaper markets and congressional districts.
- Newspapers write more about representatives when more of their readers live in the representative's district.
- Voters in more congruent areas know more about their House representative.
- Congruence does not predict general political knowledge, which supports a district-specific media mechanism.
- TV and radio congruence do not explain the main voter-knowledge results.
- Voters in more congruent places are more likely to participate in House races.
- Representatives from more congruent districts appear to work harder for constituents, especially through witness appearances.
- They vote less with party leadership and appear more moderate in close-election designs.
- Counties with higher congruence receive more federal spending per capita.
- The paper's main contribution is to show that local media-market geography has causal implications for information, accountability, and resource allocation.

8 Conclusion

8.1 Core conclusion

The paper shows that local newspaper coverage is a key input into democratic accountability. When newspaper markets align well with congressional districts, voters learn more about their House representatives. Representatives in those areas appear to work harder for their constituencies and vote less mechanically with party leadership. Counties in more congruent media environments also receive more federal spending.

8.2 Economic intuition

Newspapers face a simple coverage incentive: write about politicians who matter to their readers. When a newspaper's audience is concentrated in one congressional district, covering that district's representative is valuable. When its audience is spread across many districts, detailed coverage of any one representative is less valuable. This creates variation in voter information even in the same national political system.

8.3 What the paper does not claim

The paper does not claim that newspapers are the only source of accountability, or that all media effects are beneficial. It also does not claim that the spending effect is a pure welfare improvement; more spending may reflect better representation or more distributive politics. The central claim is narrower and stronger: relevant local press coverage improves the information environment and changes political incentives.

8.4 Final takeaway

The paper turns media-market geography into a tool for studying accountability. Its lasting lesson is that democratic performance depends not only on elections and formal institutions, but also on whether voters receive locally relevant information about the politicians who represent them.